DONGJUN KIM

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Making evals trustworthy and robust, and closing the gap between eval analysis and training decisions.
Agentic eval environments, AI safety, and mechanistic interpretability; first-author orals at ACL 2026 and EMNLP 2025.

EXPERIENCE

AI Research Engineer, LLM Evaluation & Analysis Mar 2026 – Present
Upstage (Solar Model Project) *Seoul, South Korea*

- **Trustworthy results:** Made scores reproducible and caught errors that silently changed them.
  - Found **9 of 67 benchmarks** where configured sampling settings (e.g., temperature) never reached the model; made every setting explicit and enforced it with a 22-rule CI check.
  - Audited how failed requests (API errors, timeouts, judge failures) were scored across 109 benchmarks, found that half of all retry paths never actually retried, and set one team-wide rule for scoring them.
  - Caught silent scoring bugs, like an LLM judge reusing old verdicts and blank answers scored as 54.5% correct.
- **Agentic evaluation:** Build and scale sandboxed agent environments and harnesses for long-horizon agentic evals (SWE-bench, Terminal-Bench, τ^2-bench).
  - Caught under-elicitation: Solar ran at a **32K reasoning budget instead of 131K** on 8 agentic benchmarks, so it looked weaker than it was; fixed it across 4 agent harnesses, including Claude Code and Codex.
  - Restored 10 of 13 agentic benchmarks that broke on a new checkpoint; false timeouts on one fell from 103 to 18.
- **Eval infrastructure:** Maintain Upstage's eval framework: 100+ models on 100+ benchmarks across Slurm clusters.
  - Cut a full Solar Open 2 suite ($\sim$50 benchmarks) from **several days to $\sim$7 hours** with an optimizer that packs benchmarks into single-node Slurm shards based on profiled throughput.
  - Tuned vLLM and SGLang serving and chat templates for Solar; standardized settings made evals 2.0$\times$ faster.
  - Restored a silently disabled batching option that was wasting 4$\times$ to 10$\times$ decoding on GPQA and AIME.
- **Model development:** Worked directly on **Solar Open 2** (250B MoE), **Solar Pro 4**, and **Solar Mini 4**.
  - Evaluated SFT and RL checkpoints, ran competitor baselines for the Solar Open 2 tech report, and used repeated-run ablations of sampling and serving settings to separate real gains from run-to-run noise.
  - Built **Light Bench**, reduced versions of 30 benchmarks (up to 98% faster) for comparing checkpoints; analyzed where light scores drift from full (noise floor, long-tail generations) and tested stratified sampling to close the gap.
  - Estimated Artificial Analysis's private AutomationBench score from public-set runs (15 models, 5.3-point RMSE).
  - Built leaderboards and comparison reports (score deltas, per-question diffs) for the training team and executives.
- **Eval logs:** Built a pipeline that records every model call (evaluated model, judge, user simulator) under one schema for every benchmark in the framework, even ones that don't save trajectories.
  - Backfilled 165 runs (**115K records**, zero validation errors) and linked 33K agentic trajectories.
  - Added analysis that flags degeneration, API and judge failures, and scoring anomalies.
- **Agent-native tooling:** Built the team's shared agent skills and a knowledge base every team member's agent loads, plus repo guidelines and CI that turned benchmark migration from a bottleneck into a checked process agents can run.

Graduate Researcher Jan 2024 – Feb 2026
NLP&AI Lab, Korea University *Seoul, South Korea*

- **National Foundation Model Project (VAETKI, NC AI Consortium):** Engineered the evaluation pipeline, standardizing **50+ benchmarks** into a single reproducible runtime with automated regression tracking across checkpoints.
- **Evaluation research:** Drove benchmark design (KITE) and benchmark-profiling analyses of what benchmarks actually measure, finding that most test a mix of abilities, not the single skill on their label.
- **Mechanistic interpretability:** Developed **SAE-based** feature discovery, feature steering, and causal-intervention workflows that connect internal signals to evaluation outcomes.
- **LLM Training:** Supported Korean LLM post-training and reasoning improvements.
  - **GRPO in VERL** for KULLM-R (`nobrand/KULLM-R`) with verifiable custom rewards and an adaptive length penalty.
  - Instruction tuning plus data curation for KULLM3 and Ko-Gemma.

Selected Publications

Benchmark Profiling: Mechanistic Diagnosis of LLM Benchmarks
Kim, D., Shim, G., Chun, Y. C., Kim, M., Park, C., & Lim, H. *EMNLP 2025 · Main · **Oral***

LangSAE Editing: Improving Multilingual Information Retrieval via Post-hoc Language Identity Removal
Kim, D., Yoon, J., Park, C., & Lim, H. *ACL 2026 · Main · **Oral***

Exploring Coding Spot: Understanding Parametric Contributions to LLM Coding Performance
Kim, D., Kim, M., Chun, Y. C., Park, C., & Lim, H. *ACL 2026 · Findings*

Towards Computational Comprehension: A Non-Anthropocentric Framework for Evaluating LLM Understanding
Kim, D., Shim, G., Kim, M., Park, C., & Lim, H. *arXiv · 2025*

MMAC: A Multilingual, Multimodal Alignment Framework for Cultural Grounding Evaluation
Zheng, W., . . . , **Kim, D.**, . . . , & Chen, N. F. *ACL 2026 · Main*

CultureConverse: A Multilingual Multi-turn Simulation Harness for Culturally Grounded Assistance in East and Southeast Asia
Tan, B. C. Z., Zheng, W., . . . , **Kim, D.**, . . . , & Lee, R. K.-W. *EMNLP 2026 · Main*

Solar Open 2 Technical Report
Upstage Solar Team *Technical Report · 2026*

VAETKI Technical Report
NC-AI Consortium *Technical Report · 2026*

KoLEG: On-the-Fly Korean Legal Knowledge Editing with Continuous Retrieval
Seo, J., Jung, D., Lee, J., Chun, Y. C., **Kim, D.**, Ryu, H., Shin, D., & Lim, H. *EMNLP 2025 · Findings*

Enhancing Automatic Term Extraction with Large Language Models via Syntactic Retrieval
Chun, Y. C., Kim, M., **Kim, D.**, Park, C., & Lim, H. *ACL 2025 · Findings*

CrossDocVQA: A Benchmark for Multi-Hop Cross-Document Visual Question Answering
Shim, G., Shin, J., **Kim, D.**, Park, C., & Lim, H. *arXiv · 2026*

From Snapshot to Stream: A Self-Improving Leaderboard for Robust and Evolving NLP Evaluation
Park, C., Moon, H., **Kim, D.**, Lee, S., Seo, J., Eo, S., & Lim, H. *arXiv · 2025*

Education

Korea University Seoul, South Korea
Master of Science in Computer Science *Feb 2026*

- Advisor: Prof. Heuiseok Lim (NLP&AI Lab)
- Research focus: LLM evaluation, mechanistic interpretability, and AI safety

University of South Florida Tampa, FL
Bachelor of Science in Computer Science (Cum Laude) *May 2023*

Honors & Service

Outstanding Reviewer, ACL Rolling Review (May 2026 cycle) *Oct 2026*

Reviewer, ACL Rolling Review (March 2026: 4 papers; May 2026: 6 papers), NeurIPS 2026 (4 papers) *2026*